



42

THE GAME OF 42 • FOR THE VISION FISH

Proverbs of the Game of 42

a workshopping collection drawn from the whole: a quarry, not a monument



DON'T PANIC

Forty-two proverbs and a handful of spells, distilled from the timeline so the architecture can be carried in the mouth. Offered in the spirit of the Relationship Proverb Protocol: a proverb is a promise compressed until it can be remembered. Carry them the way you carry a towel, lightly and everywhere. These are seed-lines. Cut them, invert them, argue with them. Where a line carries a [variant], both are live and neither has won yet.

I. THE WAGER

1. A lake with no shore is only a fine place to drown. Give it banks and it remembers it was a river, and a river will take you somewhere.
2. They told us privacy was the fare. It turned out to be the ride.
3. A centre is one convenient address for all the bad news to arrive at once.
4. Many singularities, one commons, and no throne worth the fight. Mostly harmless, at last.
5. What you pool, you lose. What you bound, you keep.
[variant: pool and you are mined; bound and you are paid.]
6. Do not ask who owns the water. Ask who was good enough to give it banks.

II. THE BOUNDARY AND THE BOND

7. The sword without the mage is a wall. The mage without the sword is a flood. Hold both, or hold nothing.
8. A gate that will not close is not a kindness. It is only an opening someone else found first.
9. Protect points inward, connect points out, and a self needs both directions at once.
10. Refusal is the first courtesy a boundary offers.
11. Two agents, one self: one to guard the threshold, one to stand outside it with a thumb out.

III. THE TRUST GRAPH

12. Trust is not declared. It is drawn.
13. Lay what you know over what you kept, and the shape between the two is your name.
14. Intent, then promise, then trust, and never skip the middle, for the middle is where the lying would live.
15. Keep your promises small and your graph will grow large.
16. A city is only a trust graph that held still long enough to be walked through.

IV. THE TIME BANK AND THE GIVING

- 17. The hour of the lawyer and the hour of the child weigh the same. Weigh them so on purpose.
- 18. A ledger that sums to zero has nothing to hoard and nothing to hide.
- 19. Pledge the hours you have, not the hours you meant to have.
- 20. If the room does not fill, the contract hands your hours back. This is what honesty looks like once someone has automated it.
- 21. Give until it stops feeling like loss. That number is nearer than you fear.

V. THE GAME OF 42

- 22. You cannot win by growing. You can only bud.
- 23. Six is a beginning, forty-two is a board, and the constellation is everyone else.
- 24. Forty-two is the answer they already handed us. The whole game is remembering the question.
- 25. A circle that only ever agrees with itself has quietly gone blind. Seat the stranger.
- 26. Diversity is not the ornament on the assembly. It is the load it was built to bear.
- 27. Open a game you can keep playing, not one you can win.

VI. THE ROAD

- 28. Ask five things of every plan, and believe only the fifth: what makes it feel real.
- 29. Over-generate, then grieve, then prune. The pile is not waste. The pile is compost.
- 30. Grow at the speed of trust. Anything faster is only an incident wearing a crowd.
- 31. Pack light, leave one month empty for serendipity to land in, and never set out without a towel and a reason.
- 32. The improbable is only the probable you have not yet been introduced to.

VII. THE AGENTS AND THE FISH

- 33. Build for the small thing on the desk and the vast thing in the sky, and refuse to choose. The refusal is the architecture.
- 34. Let the machine sulk locally. Even an agent deserves a room with the door shut.

35. The fish swims through where the two squares overlap. The squares are the boundary, the overlap is the commons, and the swimming is the trust.
36. The eye of the vision fish stays open underwater. That is the entire trick.
37. A guide is three curves: what you gave, what you spent, who vouched. Be hidden on one and you must be shown on another.

VIII. THE POLY-SINGULARITY, AND THE CLOSE

38. Give the river a seat and it will vote through its watershed.
39. Deliberation is not a survey with better manners. Sit for a year, and then speak.
40. Many minds, each holding its own banks, do not flood together. They run as one river and still arrive as themselves.
41. If no one wept, you built a tool. If someone wept, you built a home.
42. Print *don't panic* on the cover, and then do the harder thing, which is to mean it.



SPELLS (ROUGH, FOR THE TABLE)

These are longer than proverbs and not yet load-bearing. Read them aloud, which is the only real test.

The Emergence Spell *(after the one already carved at the door)*

*The right people arrive.
The right moment happens.
The right ending closes.
You do not recruit a game. You open one,
and trust the pattern, for the pattern trusts you.*

The Boundary Blessing

*May your wall have a gate.
May your gate have a keeper.
May your keeper know your face.
And may the water, when it comes asking,
be given banks and a heading,*

*and so become a river,
and so become a road.*

The Traveller's Charge

*Carry a towel.
Carry a question.
Stick out a thumb at the improbable.
When the lift arrives, and it will,
climb in,
mind the boundary,
tend the gap,
discover the destination,
don't panic.*

Coda: eutierria

*When the work is done and the boundary still holds,
there is a word for the quiet that follows:
not victory, which needs a loser,
but eutierria, the peace of belonging
to a living thing that kept you whole.
Don't panic. You are early, and you are welcome.
So long, and thanks for all the boundaries.*



Workshop notes: proverbs are numbered for reference, not ranked. The eight headings are a re-decomposition rather than the briefing's five named systems (wager, boundary, trust, gift, game, road, agents, plurality is a finer cut), so do not expect a one-to-one match with the five-system canon; each proverb still traces back to the part of the architecture it compresses. Suggested moves for the next pass: tighten any line that needs more than one breath; find the three that are secretly the same proverb and keep the best; and mark which of these is true enough to carve and which is only clever.